



1 Sorting

Aluminum cans are collected and taken to the recycling plant, where they are checked to make sure they don't contain anything else, such as steel, plastic, or paper containers.



2 Crushing and baling

Cans take up a lot of space, so once sorted, they are crushed flat and then pressed into bales. This process compacts the cans down to a fraction of their original volume and makes them easier to move and store.



3 Melting

The bales are then shredded, and any inks on them are removed by blasting them with hot air at a searing 930°F (500°C). The shreds are melted in a furnace at 1,380°F (750°C), poured into molds, and cooled with water.



A single ingot can be 50 ft (15 m) long and contain enough metal to make 1.5 million cans.

4 Preparing ingots

The cooled aluminum is molded into blocks called ingots, stored here in large piles. Ingots can be heated and rolled into thin sheets, which are used to make new cans or other products.